



Trello overhaul

Trello, the productivity app, unveils a host of new board designs and capabilities.
<http://digit.in/mar21-45>



MS Office for iPad

Microsoft Office mobile combines Word, Excel and PowerPoint in one cohesive app.
<http://digit.in/mar21-46>

CANONICAL IS WATCHING YOU SPIN UP VMS

Luca Bongiorno didn't know that he was in for a creepy surprise when he spun up an Ubuntu 18.04 VM on Azure Cloud. All he wanted to do was evaluate a few tools in a Linux environment and he ended up getting a Big Brother experience. Shortly after spinning up the Ubuntu instance, Bongiorno was

contacted by an Enterprise Development representative from Ubuntu on LinkedIn with a message that started off with, "I saw that you spun up an Ubuntu image in Azure". Kudos to the Canonical sales rep for being super proactive but if that's the way they approach customers, then they'd be driving customers away rather than getting more. The creepy message wouldn't have been

so surprising had Bongiorno read the ToS on the Azure Marketplace which read, "If you purchase or use a Marketplace Offering, we may share with the Publisher of such Offering your contact information and details about the transaction and your usage." Unfortunately for Bongiorno, the ToS is nowhere in sight along the workflow path that he took, and received a nasty shock. 📺

Containerising Windows applications with Docker

It's not just for Linux, you know

Everyone knows about Docker, the platform virtualisation solution that can deliver software in neat packages called containers. It works by simply packaging an application and all its dependencies within a virtual container which can then be run on any computer. This allows for rapid deployment of the application as well as the ability to migrate from one location to another. Be it from your on-premises server to your private cloud or vice-versa. Given the kind of features that enable such level of compartmentalisation, Docker was primarily thought of as a solution to be run on Linux environments. But the fact is that you can Dockerise Windows applications as well.

GETTING STARTED

To start off, you are limited to running apps that are compatible with Windows' available base images. As of now, you have the following four images:

- Windows Server Core
- Nano Server

- Windows
- Windows IoT Core

Of these, only the following can be used:

- Windows Server Core
- Nano Server

This is because the APIs that are surfaced within these two images are compatible with most of the applications that you would run. The Windows base image provides the full API set whereas the Nano Server base image is made for .NET Core applications and the Windows Server Core base image supports .NET Framework applications, MSI installers and provides 32-bit runtime support. If you plan on using Node.js or Java, then the Nano Server base image is what you'd want. It not only provides the right set of APIs but it's also very lean and makes it easier to move. Also, the added advantage of having a lean image is that you have fewer attack vectors exposed, so that's a good thing from a security perspective.

Over time, we've also seen a lot more customised base images being made available in the Docker Hub. So if you have certain dependencies across your projects then you can always pick one of these images since they do come tested. If you want an

environment with IIS installed then there's the Windows IIS base image, and if you want ASP installed then there's the ASP.NET base image. Similarly, you have the OpenJDK and Go Lang images as well. So you can see that a good set of the most commonly used environments are already available as base images.

A word of caution though, like most pre-baked images available on cloud services, updating these images isn't so cut and dry. If you've ever used a Bitnami stack on AWS or GCP, you'll have realised that updating one element of the stack, let's say PHP, isn't easy and it's better to spin up a new instance with the latest Bitnami stack and migrate your entire project. These Docker base images are a bit like that and you get updated images on a monthly cadence.

PRIMING THE ENVIRONMENT

It's understood that none of the base images will have all the dependencies that you want for your applications. They are, after all, base images. Thankfully, the entire process is straightforward. You have PowerShell in Windows Server Core and Nano Server images so for folks who prefer the command line, there's an easy way to install all your dependencies using cmdlets. And as always, the Dockerfile needs to be robust. When writing your Dockerfile ensure that it covers all the dependencies that you may require and nothing more. A minimal image makes it easy to migrate your project and it also